

TV SHOW

Another Life

★★★★☆ | First, let's start with the good. This science fiction show feels like a combination of Star Trek, Battlestar Galactica, Childhood's End, Arrival and seems to be heading towards Colony as well. The spaceships are pretty cool, and there's plenty of planet hopping, with real locations. Dark matter, black holes, rogue planets... all of it is there. There is FTL travel, with what looks like an alcubierre drive. The AI follows the tradition of HAL, GERTY and TARS. Things go downhill as expected, but the path taken is complex and nuanced. The crew is diverse, and there are a few unconventional yet believable relationships. Common gender stereotypes are subverted. The wife is the captain of a



spaceship and goes away adventuring, while the scientist husband stays back and looks after their daughter while figuring out what the aliens want. So this

show is decidedly woke, but the agenda is not forced.

Now the bad. Some of the character arcs are rushed and seem forced. The crew could really do with some better decontamination approaches. Even the Apollo 11 astronauts spent 3 weeks in quarantine, in case they brought home some space bugs. These guys make first contact at least 4 times and just get down and dirty with themselves. None of the established protocols of planetary exploration are followed. The agreed upon ethics of space exploration are heavily diluted to move the story along. Still, it is easy to look past these problems.

The show is about exploring the inner minds of the crew as much as outer space, which can be a bit overwhelming, but is what makes the show compelling and different at the end of the day. The show is not for everyone, but there is enough to get really into it, and the concepts are new.

TV SHOW

Sacred Games S2

★★★★☆ | Ganesh Gaitonde (Nawazuddin Siddiqui) and Sartaj Singh (Saif Ali Khan) make a much-awaited comeback with the second instalment of Sacred Games on Netflix, a show that quickly became a testament to the fact that stellar TV series can originate from India, aside from the onslaught of Ekta Kapoor dramas. The second season delves deeper into the intricacies of new-ish characters such as Guruji, Trivedi, Jojo and more, each of whose storylines hold promise but are ultimately ruined by poorly fabricated character progressions and associated storylines.

The second season also seems rather lacking in the urgency, unabashed humour and heart-tugging moments that were plentifully dispersed across Season One. While the plot is still fast-paced enough to keep you interested throughout the length of the eight episodes,



a sense of melodrama slowly starts creeping in during the last few episodes, with the last one being downright comical as Sartaj Singh and a bunch of other supporting characters race to save Mumbai from doomsday. This season also struggles to evoke intellectual curiosity of any kind and sort of takes you through the humdrum storyline without making you take a moment to really think about the implications of what is being shown on screen.

However, scenes involving the cop Majid (Aamir Bashir) do evoke

an emotional response to the plight of Muslim citizens in a country that blatantly discriminates on basis of religion. However, Guruji's storyline is where the show starts to fail, since his 'preachings' or speeches aren't that intriguing or profound in any way to elicit such a sudden transformation in the protagonist, Gaitonde. Performances by Kalki Koechlin and Ranvir Shorey are largely forgettable as well. Overall, we recommend you give this season a miss unless you are a stickler for completion.